



1 **WELCOME TO LATIN AMERICA**

Latin America was born in blood and fire, in conquest and slavery. It is conquest and its sequel, slavery, that created the central conflict of Latin American history. So that is where any history of the region must begin. On the other hand, conquest and slavery is old news, and partly, well, it's "history." The Latin America of 2023 is no longer your parents' version.

Still, conquest and colonization form the unified starting place of a single story, told here with illustrative examples from many countries. We need a single storyline because rapid panoramas of twenty national histories would merely produce dizziness. And, before beginning the story, we must set the stage in a number of ways. We need to ask, first of all, whether so many countries can really share a single history. At first blush, one might doubt it. Consider everything that story will have to encompass. Consider the contrasts and paradoxes of contemporary Latin America.

Latin America is the "global south," still struggling to attain the standard of living of Europe or the United States. It has deep roots in Indigenous cultures. Most of the world's Indigenous Americans, by far, live south of the Rio Grande. Yet Latin America is also the West, a place where more than nine out of ten people speak a European language and practice a European religion. Most of the world's Roman Catholics are Latin Americans, which has much to do with the first non-European pope, chosen in 2013, being Argentine.

Some Latin Americans still grow corn and beans on small plots hidden among banana trees and dwell in earthen-floored houses

with sagging red-tile roofs. International travelers who jet in and out of sprawling Latin American metropolises rarely see them. You have to go to the countryside, with its awful roads. Most Latin Americans these days live in noisy, restless cities, some of them postmodern megacities. Buenos Aires, São Paulo, and Mexico City have far outstripped the ten-million mark. Rio de Janeiro, Lima, and Bogotá are not far behind.

Next, consider the contrasts among countries. Brazil is a behemoth, occupying half the South American continent, its population surging beyond 210 million. Mexico follows at around 130 million. Thanks partly to their burgeoning internal markets, both countries' economies have even spawned their own multinational corporations. Colombia, Argentina, Peru, and Venezuela constitute a second rank, with populations between 30 and 50 million. Chile's population of 20 million carries disproportionate economic weight because of its high standard of living. The remaining, roughly one quarter, of Latin Americans live in a dozen sovereign nations, most with populations under 10 million. In sum, the major Latin American countries are global players (though nothing like China or India), while many others are ministates with a single city of consequence and two or three main highways.

Latin American climates and landscapes vary more than you may realize. Most of Latin America lies in the tropics, with no well-defined spring, summer, fall, and winter. Many readers of the global north will envision beaches replete with palms. Latin America's coastal lowlands do often match that description, but this tourist's eye view is misleading overall. Tropical *highlands* cooled by their altitude and often semiarid have played a larger role in Latin American history. Mexico City stands above seven thousand feet; Bogotá above eight thousand. Latin American mountains are the world's most densely populated for historical reasons. Meanwhile, Chile, Argentina, and Uruguay—sometimes called the "Southern Cone" of South America—lie mostly or entirely outside the tropics, with climates similar to

parts of the United States. The continent's craggy southern tip is a land of glaciers and Antarctic influences.

Socially, Latin America is a place of extreme inequalities. Enormous disparities of wealth and well-being exist within countries and between them. Today many Latin Americans live and work in circumstances not so different from those of middle-class people in the United States. But many, more than those who seem middle-class by international norms, still inhabit hovels and endure a poverty and deprivation rare in the developed world. The Southern Cone countries have long stood respectably high in global rankings of social development, and most Latin American countries now hold middling rank, globally, in a combined measure of people's education, life expectancy, and buying power. The small countries of Central America (notably excepting Costa Rica) are worse off, as are those with large and historically oppressed populations of Indigenous people, like Guatemala and Bolivia.

Latin America is probably the most racially diverse of world regions, fed from the gene pools of Europe, Africa, and Indigenous America. All three elements are present in every country, and the possible configurations vary kaleidoscopically. Guatemala and Bolivia, along with Peru and Ecuador, are characterized by large populations of Indigenous people who continue to speak native languages such as Quechua or Aymara, live more or less separately from Spanish speakers, and follow distinctive customs in clothing and food. African genes are a predominant element of the mix in Brazil and on the shores of the Caribbean. Latin America was *the* main destination of the millions of people enslaved and taken out of Africa between 1500 and 1850. Whereas the United States received about 523,000 enslaved immigrants, Cuba alone got more, Brazil at least 3.5 million. In addition, there are places in Latin America where people look notably European, particularly where large numbers of Italian immigrants were added to the population around 1900, such as in Argentina and Uruguay. Probably most Latin Americans consider

themselves to some degree “of mixed race,” or *Mestizo*, a key concept in Latin American history.

Returning to our initial question, then, do these twenty countries in their startling variety really have a single history? No, in the sense that a single story cannot encompass their diversity. Yes, in the sense that all have much in common. They experienced a similar process of conquest and colonization. They became independent more or less the same way, mostly at the same time. They then struggled with similar problems in similar ways. Looking back after two centuries of independence, one sees that similar trends have washed over the entire region, giving Latin American history a well-defined ebb and flow.



PABLO. Pablo was a little boy who lived at a Colombian boardinghouse in 1978, when I lived there, too. On hot

afternoons, Pablo sometimes took a bath in the back patio of the house, the *patio de ropas*, where several women washed the boarders' clothes by hand. Until I so rudely interrupted him, he was singing on this particular afternoon, as happy as any little boy anywhere, despite the modest character of our dollar-a-day accommodations.

NOT YOUR PARENTS' VERSION

Lately, it's been more flow than ebb. Enormous changes have come to Latin America in the fifty years since I traveled there for the first time, during the Cold War. Yes, youngsters, that was before the Internet! Telephones and postal services worked poorly or not at all in many countries of Latin America. It was impossible to stay connected to the United States on a daily basis. One experienced total immersion.

There was a hint of timelessness, too—even still the occasional burro or oxcart to glimpse from the window of a cross-country bus. Few rural dwellings had electricity or running water. The countryside seemed a feudal zone, dominated by large landowners who were rarely to be found on their rural estates because they lived in the cities. The poor people who did live in the countryside were amazingly isolated, although fairly well fed compared to the urban poor. I remember staying a few nights in a house that stood on an Andean mountainside, a ten- or fifteen-minute climb from the road, impassible by any sort of vehicle. The family who lived up there reckoned the hour by the sun and the passage of two or three buses a day visible on the road that threaded a yawning chasm, far below. An unimaginable variety of fruit grew around them, but any kind of store was half a day away.

Rural-urban migrants had been flowing into Latin American cities for decades before my arrival, although the only accompanying construction boom had been the improvised housing that the migrants built for themselves. At the height of the Cold War, Latin American cityscapes still mostly resembled the 1940s or 1950s. There were no malls, or practically none, and few major infrastructural projects in the cities. There were few US brand-name

consumer goods for sale because high import tariffs made them too expensive for almost anyone. The idea was to protect and encourage local industries. There was already a rising tide of Asian imports, although not yet from China, which has become so suddenly a player in Latin America. Cold War China was Mao's China, where people wore only blue and rode only bicycles and factories were a thing of the future. Latin America's high protective tariffs meant that imported blenders, televisions, and audio tape players had to be smuggled in, or sold in a variety of "free trade" venues created by various governments of the region in recognition of the inevitable. Before the era of inexpensive Asian manufactures, the clothing of Latin America's destitute millions was put together by hand and often seemed about to come apart at the seams like the first pants that I had made in Colombia by a tailor who worked sitting in the doorway of his shop, the size of a large closet.

The streets of cities were not studded with US fast-food franchises, as now, nor did they overflow yet with cars, which were too expensive for most people to own. Thus there was no need, yet, to create laws keeping cars (with odd-numbered plates, for example) off the road on certain days or hours, as many Latin American cities do today for sheer lack of street space. Diesel-belching buses, yes, however—lots of those. Innovative bus rapid transit systems with dedicated high-speed lanes, such as the one first created in Curitiba, Brazil (and now re-created in a series of major Latin American cities), remained on the drawing board. There were a few supermarkets in the richest parts of town, but most people did not buy food in supermarkets. Instead, there was a complex of open markets for produce and commodities and neighborhood stores and bakeries for daily staples. In sum, Latin America's middle classes were smaller and much less Americanized than today. Strong trading blocs like NAFTA and Mercosur were decades away.

Nobody had a cell phone until the 1990s, and many people had no telephone at all. Then cell phone use rocketed in Latin American cities, precisely because landlines had always been scarce. At least in

Colombia, where I first rented a place, you had a telephone in your house, or you didn't, period. Forget about getting one if you didn't, because state-run telephone companies rarely added lines. Houses were rented, bought, and sold with existing lines. A house with a telephone brought a better price, obviously. Before the era of plastic digital watches, a wristwatch of any kind was a prestige item in Latin America. People sometimes wore watches that didn't keep time, just to maintain their image. Few urban people seemed to possess a credit card, wear seat belts, have insurance coverage, or fuss over their diet except to worry about their weight if they were women. No one had heard of multiculturalism or of threats to the rain forest. Sociology was for revolutionaries, and psychology was for the insane. Remittances from people working in the United States were not yet a major source of income in the region. Mexican immigration to the United States was growing, but not yet a flood, and Central American immigration had hardly begun. Large cities were well-known hotspots, but, overall, street crime was moderate by comparison with recent decades.

Yes, those were the good old days—for me, anyway. I noticed, by the way people treated me, that I had become better looking. At greetings, I learned to embrace my buddies and shake hands with their girlfriends. The relationships between men and women seemed to me very old-fashioned and stylized. My first Spanish-language flirtations were supervised by dutiful younger sisters who were assigned to surveil me constantly. Fortunately, they could be bought off with money to go get a Popsicle, or better yet, go see a movie. In Mexico, at least, girls still did a lot of courting at the evening paseo, when people walked in circles around the town plaza, half in one direction and half in the other, occasionally switching, so that everyone eventually saw everyone. Daytime park benches were full of teenagers kissing because young people didn't have cars. (Wait. Maybe that hasn't changed.) The evening meeting place, on the other hand, was at the girl's house, under the watchful eye of her family, *not* inside but at the doorway, or even—although this was pretty old-fashioned even then—at the window, he outside, she

inside, separated by wrought-iron bars. Companionate marriage (focused on the personal compatibility of the couple) was far from unknown, but didn't seem to prosper. Male infidelity was the rule, rather than the exception. I'm not so sure how much has changed, in that regard. But clearly, these days middle-class women are much more likely to hold a job and middle-class husbands are more likely to accept, at least in principle, that they ought to share household duties.

Many cultural patterns were quite conservative. People rarely went to Mass, but their Catholicism was automatic and unquestionable. Young people of a respectable family did *not* cohabit before marriage. The ubiquitous public presence of Catholic religious devotion had yet to be challenged by growing numbers of evangelical Christians. Perfectly ordinary middle-class people had live-in maids who earned an unbelievable pittance, inhabited tiny windowless cubicles at night, and were treated, whether cruelly or kindly, as a different category of human being. Often they came from the country, where, it was believed, people were more honest and hardworking. Urban middle-class families with provincial roots might bring trustworthy servants with them to the city. City girls, even very poor ones, were unlikely to stay long as live-in maids, simply because they had more alternatives, so savvy housewives with means preferred to hire country girls who didn't know their way around. Eventually, though, even the country girls found something less humiliating to do than being a servant. The *muchacha* (of any age) has walked out again, a perennial problem for the *ama de casa*!

Only a tiny minority attended universities, and most who did studied to be lawyers, doctors, engineers, or architects. As students, they did not take part-time jobs waiting tables, for example, even if they needed the money. Class consciousness. Some were born to serve, apparently, others to be served. During the 1980s and afterward, those who were born to be served moved increasingly into high-rise apartment buildings or strongly enclosed apartment complexes with armed guards at the gate, an ugly reality that is likely to shock

anyone who has never experienced it. At least, I would like to think so. This is the aspect of Latin America that most disturbed me personally, and it hasn't gone away. Still today, the expanding middle classes of Latin America are trying to raise perfect children in a defensive crouch. Although indicators of social well-being are improving, Latin America's distribution of wealth remains among the most unequal in the world. What nobody expects these days, however, is a revolution, and that's precisely what *was* expected of the Latin America I encountered in the 1970s.

Revolutionary organizations spray-painted slogans on every available urban surface, featuring the Communist Party's hammer and sickle, the iconic visage of Che Guevara, and an alphabet soup of acronyms representing worker federations, guerrilla armies, and student organizations. Walls sprouted jagged crowns of broken glass embedded in concrete, as families with something to defend fortified themselves against the urban poor. A "population explosion," as they named it, was under way when I got to Latin America. Latin American women had high fertility rates, and twentieth-century improvements in public health were lengthening life expectancies. Demographers read the tea leaves and foretold disaster. Hunger and deprivation on a vast scale seemed the inevitable result. The threat of impending social cataclysm hovered over everything. No one suspected that the women's interest in having lots of children would drop so precipitously as their horizons expanded in the cities. But that was happening by the 1980s, and today Latin America's population is graying faster than it is growing. The future has a way of not turning out as you expect.

During the Cold War, when the Soviet Union rivaled the United States militarily, Latin America became a sort of battleground or geopolitical chessboard. Marxist guerrillas and nationalist regimes squared off against their own armed forces, which were allied with the US military. That story will be told in detail toward the end of the book. Suffice it to say, for now, that since the Cold War the region has seen sustained economic growth and political stability. But

current free-market growth seems to make the rich richer, the middle class more middle class, and the poor comparatively poorer. In Latin America, where the idea of a middle-class majority is not a reality but, rather, a fond aspiration for the future, that kind of growth can produce more losers than winners. Winners and losers. Rich and poor. Conquerors and conquered. Masters and slaves. That is the old, old conflict at the heart of Latin American history. Aspects of it go right back to 1492.

Europeans no longer ride on the backs of Indigenous porters, as they once did in Colombia, or in sedan chairs carried by African slaves, as in Brazil. But everywhere in Latin America, wealthier people still have lighter skin and poorer people still have darker skin. The descendants of the Spanish, the Portuguese, and later European immigrants to Latin America still hold power, and the people who descend from slaves and subjugated "Indians" still serve them. Half a millennium later, this is clearly the enduring legacy, rippling across the centuries, of the fact that African, European, and Indigenous American people did not come together on neutral terms, like various pedestrians arriving simultaneously at a bus stop. On the contrary, they have a history. To understand Latin America, you've got to understand that history. That's what this whole book is about.

Here it is in a nutshell: In the 1550s, Spanish and Portuguese colonizers imposed their language, their religion, and their social institutions on Indigenous Americans and enslaved Africans, people who labored for them in the mines and fields and who served them, too, at table and in bed. After three centuries of this, things began to change (at least partly) when Latin American countries became independent. Independence created a string of the world's first constitutional republics in the 1820s. Henceforth Latin American nations were to rule themselves. Rule of the people, by the people, for the people. Sound familiar? That was the plan, anyway. For most of two centuries, it didn't work very well, partly because of the weight of Latin America's conflictive history. Two political ideologies took center stage.

The first was classical *liberalism*. You may need to acquire a new understanding of liberalism here. Notice that in Latin America liberalism does *not* refer to the special concern for the welfare of disadvantaged people, as it does in the twenty-first-century United States. Instead, liberalism means limited government and economic laissez-faire. This is a larger, more historical, more international use of the word *liberalism*, referring, in short, to the core principles of the US Constitution—a complex of values and practices that developed in the 1600s and 1700s, largely in France and England. This classic liberalism favored progress over tradition, reason over faith, universal over local values, and the free market over government control. In principle, at least, liberals espoused equality of citizenship over entrenched privilege and lauded representative democracy over all other forms of government. Both 1776 and 1789 (marking the American and French revolutions, respectively) are landmark dates in world liberalism. Latin American liberals have generally been friends of the United States and of international capitalism. Today's *neoliberals*, discussed in the last chapter, are a case in point.

Neoliberals want Latin America to get with the (globalization) program. Latin American liberals have almost always been oriented toward European or US models, and that goes double for today's neoliberals. Overall, the European and US experience with liberalism has produced prosperity. The liberal state, and its economic adjunct, free-market capitalism, currently constitute the “universal” model for modernity in the global West. Latin America's actual experience with liberalism and capitalism, on the other hand, has been mixed, as we will see. Unfettered economic laissez-faire has rarely produced durable, equitable prosperity in Latin American countries. Rather, it has tended to further empower and benefit people already at the top of these starkly stratified societies. Sometimes it has created nightmare scenarios.

The second emerging political ideology, liberalism's great challenger in Latin America, was *nationalism*. Here is another big historical idea

to fine-tune in your thinking, especially if you tend to regard nationalism simply as a threat to free trade. Over the last two centuries, the surface of the entire globe has been converted from kingdoms and empires into sovereign nations, a breathtaking transformation. Nationalism is thus a major theme in modern world history, sometimes destructive, sometimes constructive. In a nutshell, nationalism is the idea that everyone ought to be part of a nation, and that nations should rule themselves. The last part makes nationalism the basic ideology of decolonization around the world. The first part, about everyone belonging, links ruling elites to the people they rule and also links the ruled to each other. The stronger those links are, the stronger the nation. In Latin America, nation building has been a long-term project carried out, over the entire nineteenth century, in artistic circles, government ministries, and eventually, public schools. In the twentieth century, nationalism has rallied the masses and challenged liberal values like free trade.

Nationalism is neither right nor left on the political spectrum. More than an ideology, per se, it is a way of rallying the masses. The great power of nationalism lies in its appeal to the idea of a national family. A family with parents in charge is rarely egalitarian, but in principle a family is inclusive and takes care of its own. Families generally close ranks against outsiders. Therefore, nationalist appeals often focus on perceived "enemies of the nation," which may be internal or external. Nationalists oppose outside control, which is why they very often resist colonialism or imperialism. They celebrate their own national uniqueness. Many Latin American nationalists are *hard-right* conservatives who value hierarchical traditions, most especially religious ones. Others are social democrats who prize the inclusiveness of nationalist appeals, the idea that a national family zealously protects its weaker members. That sort of nationalist usually stands *to the left* of liberals on the political spectrum. Some nationalists, finally, are demagogues who exploit the emotional power of nationalist appeals in an effort to scapegoat internal enemies and provoke military action against external ones. For them, nationalism

is a useful distraction from the shortcomings of their own governance.

Liberalism and nationalism have alternated in ascendancy, overall, for a century, and their rivalry isn't over yet. Latin American history involves much more than politics and economics, however. Latin American history also involves rich culture and fascinating people, not to mention considerable blood and fire. Before we begin our story, however, there is a final consideration.

OLD THINKING ON LATIN AMERICA

Latin America today requires new thinking, but there's plenty of old thinking still around. This concise history is for US readers who are encountering Latin American history for the first time. Such readers need an acquaintance with old thinking on Latin America, because examples of it float freely in our popular culture and continue to influence our ideas. A thumbnail summary will serve the purpose.

Latin American history, in the traditional US view, has long been a story of failure. Until roughly the 1930s, the interpreters of Latin America focused largely on race and culture, considering the Latin American varieties defective goods. "Hot-blooded Latins" with too much "nonwhite blood," according to this out-moded idea, simply lacked the self-discipline and the brains to make stable, prosperous, democratic societies. As Catholics, they lacked a "Protestant work ethic" (to make work not just a necessity, but a virtue), and their tropical climates further discouraged economic activity with debilitating heat and too many sensuous satisfactions—such as papayas and passion fruit—quite literally growing on trees. In this version, Latin American history was racially, culturally, and environmentally "determined" and more or less inescapably so.

Between 1940 and 1960, World War II and its intellectual aftershocks put that sort of determinism out of style. US historians of Latin America replaced the former villains of the region's history (those pesky Indigenous and African genes) with new bad guys: backward mentalities and traditional social structures that would have to be "modernized" so that Latin America could advance along the developmental trail blazed by other countries. While the modernization theory was an advance over racial and environmental determinism, it maintained existing stereotypes. Greedy landowners

and backward rulers took over from congenital laziness and tropical heat as explanations for Latin American problems. Those explanations continued to focus the onus of responsibility on Latin America itself.

During the 1960s, however, historians of Latin America became convinced that earlier interpretations of regional problems were a convenient way to blame the victim. European colonialism and outside intervention and the struggle of oppressed people to rise up against their oppressors—here, they thought, were the true explanations of current political turmoil. The triumphant Cuban Revolution set the tone for 1960s interpretations of Latin America. Historians theorized that Latin America's historically subordinate position in the global economy explained its failure to "modernize." Latin American countries occupied permanently peripheral positions vis-à-vis industrial and financial centers in Europe and the United States. The recommended solution, at a time when Marxism remained intellectually influential, was revolution at home and withdrawal from the global capitalist system. Dependency theory, as it was called, held sway through the 1970s and 1980s, but ran out of steam after the Cold War.

MODERN LATIN AMERICA



The countries and their cities listed are as follows: Cuba with Havana; Haiti; Dominican Republic with Santo Domingo; Puerto Rico; Jamaica; Mexico with Mexico City; Guatemala with Guatemala City; Honduras with Tegucigalpa; El Salvador with San Salvador; Nicaragua with Managua; Costa Rica with Santa Fe; Panama with Panama City; Venezuela with Caracas; Columbia with Bogotá; Ecuador with Quito; Guyana; Suriname; French Guiana; Peru with Lima and Cuzco; Bolivia with La Paz; Brazil with Recife, Salvador or Bahia, Brasilia, Rio de Janeiro, and São Paulo; Paraguay with Asunción; Chile with Santiago; Argentina with Buenos Aires; Uruguay with Montevideo. The Amazon River flows through northern Brazil and eastern Peru.

Today, the old certainties are all gone. Dependency theory still offers valid insights, but it has come to seem old-fashioned. Now it's revolution that has gone out of style, as Latin America's capitalist economies and liberal democracies seem to be working better, overall, than ever before. In the United States, interest in Latin America now focuses on matters that preoccupy us at home. At the beginning of the twenty-first century, both the humanities and the social sciences have given new prominence to the ways in which race, class, gender, and national identities are "constructed" in people's minds. As US citizens explore new ways of thinking about their own society, they find valuable comparative perspectives in Latin America. Therefore, US studies of Latin American history often have a cultural emphasis today. In the pages ahead, watch for new concepts. They are just as valuable to your understanding as new facts.

Now let's go back five hundred years to begin our story.

CHAPTER REVIEW



KEY TERMS AND VOCABULARY

[liberalism](#), p. 9

[nationalism](#), p. 10

STUDY QUESTIONS

1. Can you describe contrasts among various Latin American countries?
2. How is it possible to combine them in a single historical narrative?
3. What kinds of changes have characterized the region in recent decades?
4. How has thinking on Latin America evolved in the United States?

Glossary

[liberalism](#)

a cluster of political ideas, emphasizing *liberties* of various civil, political, and economic kinds. Latin American liberalism focused on European and, later, US models.

[nationalism](#)

a political movement (dominant in the mid-1900s) espousing a strong state, national pride, and economic development. Latin

American nationalists oppose “imperialist” outside influence. Often, but not always, they show a real commitment to defending the poor majority.